

Spotlight Haryana

Haryana in Beijing

Haryana has eventually emerged as a sporting giant on national mindscape. Vijender Singh's rain of punches at Beijing Olympics was a formal announcement of the fact. While he was the one who ensured the national anthem is played in the games arena, Akhil was first off the block, kindling imagination of a medal-starved nation like never before.

The dominance of Bhiwani in national boxing is total. Four out of five Beijing-bound marauders were from here. As if the entire nation made way for them in deference to their unquestionable supremacy.

Five others sportspersons, though not as spectacular, were also there; contributing in their ways, inspiring youth from Haryana to take to sports and aspire for sky. Among the four plus five who constituted the single largest state constituent in the national Olympic squad were: Boxing (Akhil, Vijender, Jatinder and Dinesh), Judo

"The state is providing the best of everything to its players. Whether it is infrastructure, equipment, coaches, cash awards or scholarships, the government is generous to the fault and giving them it all. Yet essentially it is the grit and passion of the Haryana sportspersons that brought them here".

- Ms Kiran Chaudhry
Minister of State for Sports and Youth Affairs

(Divya), Wrestling (Yogeshwar Dutt), Rowing (Devinder), Athletics (Krishna Punia) and Shooting (Sanjeev Rajput).

While all credit goes to the men and women in the middle, there can be no



denying the fact that government's willingness to pull out all stops helped in a big way. An eager government took unto itself to provide state-of-art sporting infrastructure and facilities while the prodigies set their sight high. And it showered them with honour, award and jobs when they romped home triumphant.

The state's sports minister, Ms Kiran Choudhry, promises to continue supporting athletes end-to-end, "The state is providing the best of everything to its players. Whether it is infrastructure, equipment, coaches, cash awards or scholarships, the government is generous to the fault and giving them it all. Yet essentially it is the grit and passion of the Haryana sportspersons that brought them here".

Bhiwani: 'Cuba of Indian Boxing'

So with all roads leading to Bhiwani

and celebration refusing to die down, a question that naturally comes to one's mind is – for god's sake, among all places in India, why Bhiwani?

The answer lies in taking a ride to the place. Hours of drive through dusty countryside may be discouraging – it is something like a journey away from civilization. The landscape makes you think – these are the places where opportunities must be as scarce as sunlight in rainy season. So what makes boys and girls from here to reach out for stars?

You got it right. In question is the answer. It is exactly lack of opportunity that drove thousands of enterprising young men and women to seek nirvana, the proverbial escape from misery, via sports. As you venture out with the break of first sunray, you find thousands of them giving it all to the sports of their choice. What strike you are the enablers – contemporary infra-